
A Greater Flamingo flock at the Keoladeo Ghana National Park

Keoladeo Ghana National Park, Rajasthan

Formerly a private hunting reserve of the princely state of Bharatpur and named after a temple dedicated to Lord Shiva located in its core zone, Keoladeo Ghana is one of the best-known birding destinations in India. A plaque documenting the bags of waterfowl shot for sport during colonial times is a shocking reminder of the abundance of birdlife this wetland once hosted. Accessible by road and rail from Delhi, Mathura and Agra, Bharatpur is best visited from October to February. The park's star attraction, the Siberian Crane, has not been recorded for two decades. However, other target species include the Sarus Crane, Black-necked Stork, Dalmatian Pelican, Eurasian Spoonbill and Dusky Eagle-owl.


Malabar Grey Hornbill

INDIA PICTURE

Salim Ali Bird Sanctuary, Thattekad, Kerala

Commended by the late ornithologist Dr Sálim Ali as peninsular India's richest bird habitat, Thattekad is a tiny sanctuary at the foot of the Western Ghats in Kerala's Ernakulam district where the Periyar descends into the plains. The deciduous forests here are home to an array of bird species, including the Malabar Grey Hornbill, Sri Lanka Frogmouth, Black Baza, Great Eared Nightjar, Rufous Babbler and Crimson-throated Barbet. Homestays near the forest entrance offer expert guided walks along with meals and lodging.